



Map not to scale | Foreign players and Indian players born abroad (registered state not officially disclosed) — 91

format of the IPL, was held over three months with just 61 matches. In contrast, the I-League was contested in a league format with 156 games across seven months. For the ISL to gain recognition as the top-flight league, it had to transition to a longer season and introduce promotion and relegation, as recommended by the AFC's roadmap. The latest ISL season was a 13-team affair with 163 matches, including the play-offs. In comparison, the top-ranked AFC team Japan's J-League has 380 matches;

second-ranked Iran's Persian Gulf Pro League plays 161 matches; South Korea's top flight has 228; and Australia's league has 176.

Faltering national team

The instability of the top division has coincided with arguably the worst 18 months for the national team. The professional standards and overseas expertise that ISL introduced were meant to usher in improved performances, but the last decade has been a mixed bag. Two consecutive Asian Cup appearances in 2019 and 2023 notwithstanding,

the Blue Tigers have failed to make a mark internationally.

With no competitive win since November 2023, India risks missing out on Asian Cup qualification.

Eleven years ago, the ISL was Indian football's grandest carnival. What remains now is a league gasping for air.

As the clock ticks towards the expiry of its very foundation — the MRA — the question that hangs heavy in the air is: Did the league fail Indian football, or was Indian football never ready for the ISL?